

Aratus Lives and the Biographical Tradition

eul_aid: iru

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)
Dialect: Μικταὶ διάλεκτοι [Mixed Dialects](#)
Domain: Βίος [Biography](#)
Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)

Aratus Lives is the title given to a collection of ancient biographies of the Hellenistic poet Aratus of Soli. Aratus lived in the early 3rd century BCE and was famous for his astronomical poem *Phaenomena*.

The biographies themselves were not written by a single author but were compiled over a very long period, from roughly the 1st century BCE to the 8th century CE. They represent a tradition of scholarly work where details about an author's life were gathered and prefaced to copies of their writings. These prose sketches collect various stories, facts, and legends about Aratus, describing his education, his patronage at royal courts, and his connections to other famous poets.

According to modern scholars, while these Lives are crucial sources of information, they often mix historical details with later legendary material. They are typical of the ancient practice of creating literary biographies, which aimed to construct an author's persona for later readers.

The compilation is historically important because it preserves the reception history of Aratus's *Phaenomena*, which was one of the most popular and studied poems from antiquity through the Middle Ages. The centuries-long process of adding to and transmitting these biographies shows the enduring interest in Aratus within the scholarly traditions of the Greco-Roman and Byzantine worlds.

Works (14)

- Ἀστρονομικά · [Astronomical Appendix](#) · 6 passages
- Ἐκλογή ἐκ τῆς Προοιμίου Περὶ Φαινομένων · [Excerpt from Preface-Phenomena](#) · 4 passages
- Ἐξ ἑτέρων σχολίων εἰσαγωγή · [Introduction from Other Commentaries](#) · 10 passages
- Εἰσαγωγή εἰς τὸν Ἄρατον · [Introduction to Aratus](#) · 21 passages
- Περὶ ἐξηγήσεως · [Introduction to Aratus, -Interpretation](#) · 3 passages
- Πρὸς Ἰουλιανὸν ἐπιστολή · [Letter to Julian](#) · 1 passages
- Βίος Ἀράτου · [Life of Aratus](#) · 5 passages
- Βίος Ἀράτου · [Life of Aratus](#) · 2 passages
- Βίος Ἀράτου · [Life of Aratus](#) · 2 passages
- Βίος Ἀράτου · [Life of Aratus](#) · 5 passages
- Περὶ τοῦ Ζωδιακοῦ · [On the Zodiac](#) · 4 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα ἐκ τῶν Φαινομένων τοῦ Ἄρατου · [Phenomena](#) · 9 passages
- Προοίμιον εἰς τὰ Φαινόμενα τοῦ Ἄρατου · [Prooemium to Aratus' Phenomena](#) · 23 passages

